

Arlo Self-Hosted — How to Run It

Run **Arlo** on your own computer. Everything runs in Docker — when it's up, open **<http://127.0.0.1:9005>**. Pick one method below; you only need to do this once.

What is Arlo?

Arlo is a customer-service and sales agent you host yourself. It answers from *your own* documents, cites the passage each answer came from, and hands over to a person the moment it should. Web chat, WhatsApp, Telegram, Messenger, Instagram, TikTok and email arrive in one inbox.

AutoBricks AI (autobricksai.com) is the model provider — one key for Claude, GPT, Gemini and more. Arlo speaks to it natively, so there is no second account to open.

Before you start

1. Install [Docker Desktop](#) and make sure it's running (whale icon).
2. Get your key at creators.autobricksai.com/account/api-keys/keys → create → copy the `abai_sk_live_...` value.
3. Decide the administrator's email address — it becomes the only account that can reach `/admin`.

One-time ~330 MB image download, ~500 MB on disk. The first start applies eighty database migrations before it answers, so give it a few minutes — once.

Pick a method

A macOS / Linux

```
git clone https://github.com/adit-firdaus/arlo-ai-selfhost.git arlo && cd arlo
./bootstrap.sh http://127.0.0.1:9005 you@company.com
docker compose up -d --wait
```

The second command generates every secret and writes `.env`, `db.env` and `auth.env`. Run it once, never twice.

B Windows 10 / 11

The same three commands as **A** — but run them in **Git Bash** (comes with [Git for Windows](#)) or a **WSL** terminal. PowerShell cannot run `bootstrap.sh`.

Docker Desktop must be using the **WSL 2** backend — its installer sets this up.

C Let Claude do it (any OS)

Open Claude Code and paste this one line. It installs Docker if missing, writes the stack, starts it, and asks you only for the key, the email and a password you choose yourself:

```
https://raw.githubusercontent.com/adit-firdaus/arlo-ai-selfhost/main/SETUP.md
```

It resumes if interrupted, and verifies every step before telling you it's done.

After it's running

- Create your account — this prints a code and the link to use it:

```
docker compose exec app node scripts/invite.mjs you@company.com
```

- Open **<http://127.0.0.1:9005/login?code=ARLO-XXXX-XXXX>** and choose your own password.
- Paste your AutoBricks key in **Settings** → **model provider**, and the same key into `EMBEDDINGS_KEY=` in `.env`, then `docker compose up -d --wait app`.
- Upload a few documents under **Knowledge base** — until you do, the bot honestly declines to answer rather than inventing anything.

Keep a copy of `.env`, `db.env` and `auth.env` somewhere safe. `SECRET_KEY` inside `.env` is what every stored key and token is encrypted with — without that file, a database backup cannot be read.

Managing it

All from the folder you cloned into:

```
docker compose logs -f app      # view logs
docker compose restart app      # restart (do this after connecting a Telegram bot)
docker compose pull && docker compose up -d --wait  # update
docker compose down            # stop (keeps data)
docker compose exec -T db pg_dump -U postgres -Fc postgres > arlo.dump  # back up
```

Never run `docker compose down -v` unless you mean to destroy the database — it is the only command here that loses anything.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Docker daemon isn't running	Start Docker Desktop, wait for the whale icon, retry.
bad interpreter on Windows	You're in PowerShell. Use Git Bash or WSL.
permission denied ... docker.sock (Linux)	<code>sudo usermod -aG docker \$USER</code> , then log out and back in.
First start seems stuck	It isn't — eighty migrations run before it serves. Watch <code>docker compose logs -f app</code> .
address already in use on 9005	Something else holds the port. Stop it, or change ports: in <code>compose.yml</code> and <code>PUBLIC_URL</code> .
Bot replies "I couldn't find information..."	Working as designed — the knowledge base is empty. Upload documents.
Telegram connects but nothing arrives	<code>docker compose restart app</code> . The polling loop only starts in the main process.
fetch failed on a connector, now and then	Add <code>NODE_OPTIONS=--network-family-autoselection-attempt-timeout=3000</code> to <code>.env</code> , restart.

Q&A

Does it cost anything?

Arlo is free. Only model usage counts, billed to your AutoBricks balance.

Is my data private?

Yes — everything stays on your machine. Only a question and the passages needed to answer it reach a model.

Do I need internet?

To reach the models, yes. Without a key Arlo runs and declines to answer.

Which model?

`autobricksai/gpt-4.1-mini` by default; `claude-sonnet-4.6` for harder work.

Space needed?

~500 MB one-time, plus your documents.

Exposed to the internet?

No — bound to `127.0.0.1`. A domain needs your own HTTPS proxy in front.

Can I put the chat on my website?

Yes — **Connectors** → **Web chat** gives you one `<script>` tag. Needs a public address.

How do I update it?

`docker compose pull && docker compose up -d --wait`. Migrations apply themselves.

How do I remove it completely?

`docker compose down -v` — deletes the database too. Then delete the folder.

Forgot my password?

Issue a fresh code: `docker compose exec app node scripts/invite.mjs you@...`

Can I connect WhatsApp or Telegram?

Yes — Telegram, WhatsApp (QR) and email work on a laptop. Messenger, Instagram, TikTok and WhatsApp Cloud need a public HTTPS address. See `INSTRUCTIONS.md`, section 5.

Full setup, all channels and backups → github.com/adit-firdaus/arlo-ai-selfhost · Need an API key? → creators.autobricksai.com/account/api-keys/keys